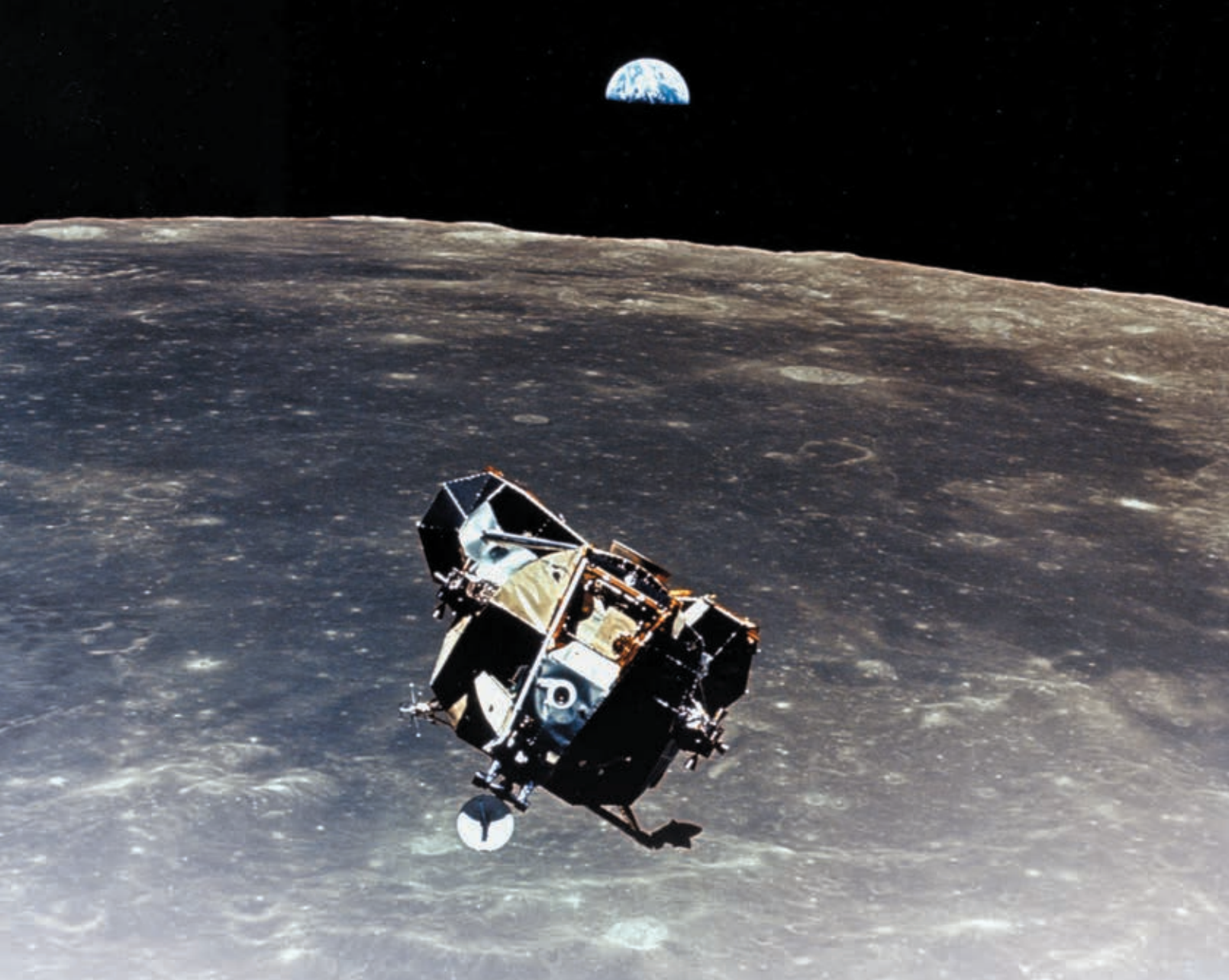




seemed to be going awry. The astronauts had enough propellant to fuel the descent engine for 12 minutes. Despite worries about overload to the onboard computer which was flying the module, the descent continued until Armstrong could see where they were going to land – in a boulder-strewn area at the edge of a crater. Taking manual control, he set off in search of a gentler landing place. The module was about 20 seconds away from running out of propellant when Armstrong brought it down, through a duststorm whipped up by the engine, coming to rest on the Sea of Tranquillity. Armstrong then spoke the famous words: “Houston, the *Eagle* has landed,”

before he and Aldrin turned to one another and shook hands.

It was another six hours before Armstrong opened the hatch and climbed down the ladder onto the Moon. He had planned to say that it was “one small step for a man, but one giant leap for mankind.” Instead, he forgot the indefinite article, calling it “a small step for man,” which made the sentence meaningless. Not that it mattered, for here was a human being standing on the Moon, witnessed by an estimated 600 million viewers on television.

Aldrin joined Armstrong in a two-and-a-half-hour moon-walk. They spent some time setting

RENDEZVOUS IN LUNAR ORBIT

With a half-Earth in the background, the lunar module ascent stage with Moon-walking astronauts Neil Armstrong and Buzz Aldrin aboard approaches for a rendezvous with the Apollo 11 command module Columbia (below) manned by Michael Collins.

